



Waiting game: Karun Nair's 602 runs in five matches for Karnataka this season, featuring both a century and a double hundred, have still failed to earn him a longer look from the Indian Test selectors. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Andhra when he was omitted from the starting lineup for the first Test against South Africa in Kolkata. Similarly, Prasidh Krishna, a regular in the Test team, was taken away from the Ranji Trophy when picked for the limited-overs series against South Africa-A. Even the significance of Ranji Trophy performances has appeared to deteriorate.

Karun Nair charted a course back into the Indian side with the help of prolific seasons with Vidarbha in the

Ranji Trophy.

However, he is out of favour again following a string of middling essays against England in the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy. His 602 runs in five games this year for Karnataka, which include a century and a double century, have been insufficient in making a case for a slightly longer rope.

Mohammed Shami's attempts at winning another shot in the Indian

team have been in vain, too. He has 20 wickets in four games at an average of 18 this season, but was not even considered for the A-side that played two multi-day games against South Africa-A. Mumbai all-rounder Shams Mulani has 28 wickets in five games, the third-highest this season. He has chipped in with the bat too and scored 285 runs at an average of 57. But his consistent performances have been overlooked, and he has found no place even in the India-A setup, let alone India.

India's drubbing at the hands of the Proteas has also brought into focus the disconnect between the Ranji Trophy and international cricket in terms of playing conditions.

This year, the pitches on offer have been flatter than usual, despite the BCCI advising the State units to produce livelier tracks. Till the fifth round of this season, bowlers' strike rate in the first two innings of a match stood at 66, the worst since 2017/18. Though the batters' average over the first two innings has increased only marginally, their dismissal rate (balls faced per wicket) has ticked past 64 deliveries this year. In Tests played in India, batters' dismissal rate has been 64 or more only twice (2016/17 and 2017/18) in the last 10 years.

The team scores are another gauge of the conditions. Teams have scaled 500 runs in 24 innings this season, just five short of last season's tally and on course to near the haul of 37 from 2012/13 — the highest since the turn of the millennium.

Batters lasting longer at the crease has reflected in the results too. Out of the 80 games in the Elite Groups, only 43 matches have culminated in a result. A result rate of 53 per cent in the Ranji Trophy is the lowest since 2016/17. It has been

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